



Vik Muniz reconstructions

Vik Muniz made an art form out of making replicas of versos, and exhibits them around the world. <https://digit.in/feb20-43>



The secrets of versos

Explore the details hidden away in the versos of other paintings, and how they document the history of the artwork. <https://digit.in/feb20-44>

FAMOUS VERSOS

What secrets do the backs of paintings hold?

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The backs of paintings, also known as versos or the obverse side, can have a lot of information that tells about the provenance and history of the painting. There may be labels or marks indicating that the work belonged to a particular collection, or was loaned to an entity for an exhibition. If the painting

had a previous owner who was also famous, then the value of the work can potentially increase. Some paintings actually have art on both sides, the main or front known as the recto, and the verso. In medieval times, couples could have their portraits painted on either side, but even artists such as Vincent Van Gogh resorted to painting on both sides of a canvas when struggling for art supplies. The various scrawls and scribbles

on the back of paintings, and along the edges of the back of the woodwork can have names of painter, owners, museums and exhibitors, but also names of friends and family members of the artist. There are also likely to be indications of previous restoration efforts on a painting. Some of the versos of the most famous paintings actually have embedded technologies to continuously monitor the health of the artwork.



Credit: Hyperallegor

LA GIOCONDA

The Mona Lisa by Leonardo da Vinci uses a very humble, and now faded piece of poplar wood. Towards the top of the verso is a centuries old crack in the wood, that has been fixed by a butterfly joint by nineteenth century conservationists. This frame has an electronic instrument that pings conservationists if the gap expands by so much as a micrometer. In the spring, when the heat and humidity are considered ideal for such activities, museum workers remove the painting and perform an annual checkup. The painting is carefully scrutinized for damage caused by expansion and contraction. An earlier frame was infested with wood eating deathwatch beetles. On the verso, there are no less than five arrows that point towards which direction the painting faces up.

STARRY NIGHT

The Starry Night by Vincent van Gogh has a number of stickers on the back that shows the rich touring history of the painting. These are in the form of various museum labels, accompanied by the dates when the Museum of Modern Art (MOMA) lent out the painting. These include an exhibition at the Metropolitan Museum of Art between 1986 and 1987 in New York, as well as a 1955 loan to Musée de l'Orangerie in Paris. This second label is dense with information, noting the organisers of the exhibition in Paris, the address of the lender, as well as how MOMA acquired the painting (through the Lillie P Bliss Bequest). Vertically, on the bottom right corner has the title of the painting in big bold letters, so that no one ever gets confused. There are also notes and scribbles all over the painting, in both pencil and marker.



Credit: Vik Muniz